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## SESSION 2B

# DREADFUL REPENTANCE

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### PRIDE

The dreading of repentance, the delaying of it, and the resulting coolness in our sense of closeness with God is a huge problem facing many Christians, and it stems from some deep-seated issues. Some of the reasons are pride, the lure of self-atonement, and a failure to trust in the gospel of God's radical grace to us through Christ. Let's take these in turn.

#### **Pride or the bruised ego:**

Frankly, it hurts our pride when we mess up. When we make vows to not sin, and we do again, we experience a deep disappointment with ourselves, and this is a bitter feeling. One way not to deal with this is to not face it. But since repentance requires facing it squarely before God in honest confession, we put it off. We'd rather pretend it didn't happen, or that we'll just let some time pass before dealing with it. There's a vague sense of uneasiness about it, but we keep avoiding it.

Pride is just stupid since it keeps us away from truth, and it keeps us away from God. Coming out to the light and admitting the truth will cause us to place our faith in and appreciate the atoning sacrifice of Christ once again. We grow in our love for God, and deal a blow to our pride, which is always a good thing.

But it's worse when this pride gets hardened, and we decide to adopt the Judas response.

#### **Can you relate to this?**

**What will happen to the person who keeps persisting in this pattern?**

### SELF-ATONEMENT

This was Judas' problem. Consider the difference between Judas' and Peter's responses after they feel convicted of their wrong in betraying Jesus.



**MATTHEW 27:3-5 (ESV)**

<sup>3</sup>Then when Judas, his betrayer, saw that Jesus was condemned, he changed his mind and brought back the thirty pieces of silver to the chief priests and the elders, <sup>4</sup>saying, "I have sinned by betraying innocent blood." They said, "What is that to us? See to it yourself." <sup>5</sup>And throwing down the pieces of silver into the temple, he departed, and he went and hanged himself.

LUKE 22:60-62 (ESV)

<sup>60</sup> But Peter said, “Man, I do not know what you are talking about.” And immediately, while he was still speaking, the rooster crowed. <sup>61</sup> And the Lord turned and looked at Peter. And Peter remembered the saying of the Lord, how he had said to him, “Before the rooster crows today, you will deny me three times.” <sup>62</sup> And he went out and wept bitterly.

Judas seems to be the more righteous one, in that he faces what he has done, and decides to punish himself for it. He is remorseful, and will make it right by condemning himself by himself. And that’s the problem. It’s all about him. He will make up for it. It would be the equivalent of that ten-year-old son leaving the house, getting a job picking up trash, and sending money home to pay for the vase. This self-atonement leaves out some crucial facts.

**First, it leaves out Jesus altogether.** Judas wronged Jesus, and he should rush to him to restore the relationship by confessing his sorrow and begging for forgiveness. The relational aspect is missing entirely, as a proud and self-absorbed Judas resolutely decides to kill himself. Contrast that with Peter who, upon meeting Jesus’ gaze, weeps bitterly. He weeps because he knows he has hurt and rejected Jesus at his time of greatest need. I am sure he’s plenty ashamed of himself, but his hurt is probably the greater pain of knowing he’s inflicted a painful wound on the one he loves. Peter’s tears are tears that include Jesus, and are toward Jesus. The problem with self-atonement is that it ignores God, who is the one offended and violated when we sin. Sin is relational, and it is against God.

**Second, self-atonement doesn’t work, and insults Jesus.** It grossly underestimates the gravity of sin against the holy God, and grossly overestimates whatever we think we can do to make up for it. As sinners, the thought that through our good deeds we can make up for our transgressions is an insult to God’s provision of the cross. It is as if to say that Jesus need not have gone to the trouble of being nailed on a cross for us. Regarding the prospects of our righteousness, the scriptures say that “all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment.” (Isaiah 64:6)

Another way to express the difference between Judas’ pride-fueled remorse and true repentance is **“worldly sorrow” vs. “godly sorrow.”**



2 CORINTHIANS 7:8–10 (ESV)

<sup>8</sup> For even if I made you grieve with my letter, I do not regret it—though I did regret it, for I see that that letter grieved you, though only for a while. <sup>9</sup> As it is, I rejoice, not because you were grieved, but because you were grieved into repenting. For you felt a godly grief, so that you suffered no loss through us. <sup>10</sup> For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death.

Once someone acknowledges they sinned, there are two possibilities for the next step: godly sorrow that leads to salvation, and worldly sorrow that leads to death. Godly sorrow is sorrow toward God. It is personal, and is toward God. There’s nothing I can do. When the forgiveness comes, as it does through the cross of Jesus, it’s a fresh gift, and it’s amazing once again. I feel a closer sense of loyalty and love toward God as a result.

Worldly sorrow, on the other hand, recognizes a wrong has been done, but will not turn to God for mercy. The sorrow is allowed to fester into something more toxic, or just to discourage and destroy. In the case of Judas, it led to his actual death.

## SELF-ATONEMENT ILLUSTRATION

**Evaluate the following description of someone’s repentance.**

The whole time that my girlfriend and I were sleeping together, I attended church. I came to church hung-over most Sundays from partying hard the night before. The thing is, I was a Sunday school teacher. Then, one day I heard one of my students say angrily that she could not believe in God because she had not met any Christian who lived out what they preached. They were all hypocrites, including her parents. She looked straight at me as she was saying this, and I realized that she was including me, too, in her description. And it hit me like a ton of bricks. She was right. I was that hypocrite she was talking about. I was that hypocritical so-called Christian that put mud on the face of Jesus. I repented then and there, and vowed that I would move out of my girlfriend’s apartment, and stop the partying lifestyle. After that painful encounter, I have been faithfully teaching those 5<sup>th</sup> graders. I hope God is pleased with me.

## NOT TRUSTING IN GOD'S GRACE

A third reason people find repentance dreadful is that we imagine God as angry and barely putting up with us. We separate out God's wrath from his love, and think that our sins must be made up with a dramatic show of penitence, accompanied by grim penance in order to impress God enough to let us off the hook. God is out to punish our sins, and we keep the punishment away by repenting. We need to walk a mile on gravel roads on our bare knees to show how seriously we are taking it, and if we sin again, it's two miles.

This fundamentally misconstrues our relationship with God. But it's an easy mistake to make because of our default merit-oriented nature and experience in life. Author and pastor Tim Keller writes about this under the label of "religious repentance."

Martin Luther opened the Reformation by nailing "The Ninety-Five Theses" to the door of Wittenberg Cathedral. The very first of the theses was: "Our Lord and Master Jesus Christ...willed the entire life of believers to be one of repentance."

On the surface this looks a little bleak! Luther seems to be saying Christians will never be making much progress. But of course that wasn't Luther's point at all. He was saying that repentance is the way we make progress in the Christian life. Indeed, pervasive, all-of- life-repentance is the best sign that we are growing deeply and rapidly into the character of Jesus.

### **The Transformation of Repentance**

It is important to consider how the gospel affects and transforms the act of repentance. In "religion" the purpose of repentance is basically to keep God happy so he will continue to bless you and answer your prayers. This means that *religious* repentance is a) selfish, b) self-righteous, c) and bitter all the way to the bottom. In the gospel, however, the purpose of repentance is to repeatedly tap into the joy of our union with Christ in order to weaken our need to do anything contrary to God's heart.

### **Religious repentance is selfish.**

In religion we only are sorry for sin because of its consequences to us. It will bring us punishment – and we want to avoid that, so we repent.

The gospel tells us that sin can't ultimately bring us into condemnation (Rom 8:1.) Its heinousness is therefore what it does to God—it displeases and dishonors him.

Thus in religion, repentance is self-centered; the gospel makes it God-centered. In religion we are mainly sorry for the consequences of sin, but in the gospel we are sorry for the sin itself.

### **Furthermore, religious repentance is self-righteous.**

Repentance can easily become a form of "atoning" for the sin. Religious repentance often becomes a form of self-flagellation in which we convince God (and ourselves) that we are so truly miserable and regretful that we deserve to be forgiven. In the gospel, however, we know that Jesus suffered and was miserable for our sin. We do not have to make ourselves suffer in order to merit forgiveness. We simply receive the forgiveness earned by Christ. (1 John 1:9) says that God forgives us because he is "just". That is a remarkable statement. It would be unjust of God to ever deny us forgiveness, because Jesus earned our acceptance! In religion we earn our forgiveness with our repentance, but in the gospel we just receive it.

### **Last, religious repentance is bitter all the way down.**

In religion our only hope is to live a good enough life for God to bless us. Therefore every instance of sin and repentance is traumatic, unnatural, and horribly threatening. Only under great duress does a religious person admit they have sinned—because their only hope is their moral goodness. But in the gospel the knowledge of our acceptance in Christ makes it easier to admit we are flawed (because we know we won't be cast off if we confess the true depths of our sinfulness.) Our hope is in Christ's righteousness, not our own—so it is not so traumatic to admit our weaknesses and lapses.

In religion we repent less and less often. But the more accepted and loved in the gospel we feel the more and more often we will be repenting. And though of course there is always some bitterness in any repentance, in the gospel there is ultimately a sweetness. This creates a radical new dynamic for personal growth. The more you see your own flaws and sins, the more precious, electrifying, and amazing God's grace appears to you. But on the other hand, the more aware you are of God's grace and acceptance in Christ, the more able you are to drop your denials and self-defenses and admit the true dimensions of your sin. The sin under all other sins is a lack of joy in Christ.

### **The Disciplines of Gospel-Repentance**

If you clearly understand these two different ways to go about repentance, then (and only then!) you can profit greatly from a regular and exacting discipline of self-examination and repentance.<sup>1</sup>

- Tim Keller, "All of Life is Repentance"

**Were some of your misconceptions of repentance cleared up through this section? If so, what were they?**

## SESSION 2B QUIZ

**Which of these is NOT true about 'worldly sorrow'?**

- a) Leads to death
- b) Is toward God
- c) Recognizes a wrong has been done
- d) Is discouraging

**Which of these is NOT true about 'self-atonement'?**

- a) Doesn't work
- b) Insults Jesus
- c) Underestimates the gravity for sin
- d) Underestimates our ability to make up for it

**Which of these describes "religious" repentance? (Circle all that apply)**

- a) We are only sorry for our sin because of its consequence to us.
- b) We are sorry for the sin itself.
- c) It is God-centered.
- d) It's a way to merit forgiveness.
- e) Our only hope is to live a life good enough for God to bless us.
- f) Every instance of sin and repentance is traumatic, unnatural, and horribly threatening.
- g) It makes it easier to admit that we are flawed.
- h) We repent less and less often.

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<sup>1</sup> Keller, Tim. "All of Life is Repentance" January 1, 2000. [http://download.redeemer.com/pdf/learn/resources/All\\_of\\_Life\\_Is\\_Repentance-Keller.pdf](http://download.redeemer.com/pdf/learn/resources/All_of_Life_Is_Repentance-Keller.pdf)